

CUT • ROOT • ESTABLISH

# The fig cutting fieldbook

A practical reference for turning dormant wood into a manageable young plant—not just a photograph of an opening bud.



| FIRST                          | THEN                   | ONLY AFTER                  |
|--------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Identify wood and orientation. | Document actual roots. | Pot on and adjust exposure. |

Inside: cut maps, method comparisons, container sections, measured layouts, development plates, case decisions, and usable batch records.

24 pages. Original schematic illustrations. Worked quantities and batch outcomes are labeled examples, not prescriptions or expected success rates.

DECISION DESK

# Choose the route before the date

| What you actually have                        | Choose                               | Arrange first                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Leafless mature wood in dormancy              | Hardwood container route, pages 4–10 | Labeled material, drainage, protected space.      |
| One-year dormant stems + suitable nursery bed | Outdoor row, page 6                  | Local timing and a marked, maintained bed.        |
| Leafy soft growth                             | A dedicated softwood method          | Moisture-loss control; not a dormant-stem recipe. |
| Flexible low attached branch                  | Layering, page 21                    | Secure rooting zone; keep the parent connection.  |
| Rooted sucker                                 | A rooted-material method             | Confirm roots and prepare aftercare.              |

## Three questions that decide the next action

- 1. Is the material dormant, actively leafy, or already rooted?
- 2. Which complete protocol describes that material?
- 3. Where will the plant go after this stage?

*A calendar date without a location and plant stage is incomplete information. Do not mix a Georgia nursery-row date with a protected indoor softwood setup.*

INTAKE SHEET

# Keep the donor identity attached

| Field             | Example record                                   | Why it matters                                          |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Donor identity    | Chicago Hardy — original nursery label retained  | Names should survive separation and potting.            |
| Source            | My labeled parent tree; collection date recorded | A leaf photograph alone does not establish cultivar.    |
| Stem state        | Dormant, firm wood; soft tip excluded            | Material must match the chosen route.                   |
| Visible condition | No observed soft or expanding damaged area       | This is an observation, not a disease-free certificate. |
| Individual IDs    | CH-01 through CH-12                              | Tray position is not a permanent identity.              |

## A label that moves with the plant

CH-04 | donor: Chicago Hardy | cut: \_\_\_\_\_ | method: UF/IFAS container

Write the full donor provenance in the notebook. Mark the basal end before pieces are mixed.

| Intake decision                | Record before proceeding                                 |
|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Identity uncertain             | Use “unknown edible fig”; do not invent a cultivar.      |
| Material visibly deteriorating | Keep it out of the propagation batch pending assessment. |
| No suitable aftercare space    | Reduce the batch before taking more wood.                |

ANATOMY PLATE

# The node, the bud, the two ends

**READ THE STEM BEFORE CUTTING**

6 in / 15.2 cm

**NODE + BUD**

Retain the structure; do not cut through the bud.

**TOP**

Upper end stays upward.  
Angled cut marks orientation.

**BUD**

**BASAL END**

Cut just below a node. This end enters the medium.

UF/IFAS six-inch example; basal wood is two years old. Node spacing is schematic.

| Structure    | Your check                                                  |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Node and bud | Locate before the final cut; avoid slicing through the bud. |
| Basal end    | The original lower end enters the rooting medium.           |
| Upper end    | Keep upward; use a consistent cut-shape cue plus the label. |

*The ruler describes the UF/IFAS example, not an exact position for every node. Do not substitute drawing proportions for the actual stem.*

PROTOCOL COMPARISON

# Keep each recipe together

| Source / setting          | Material                                                               | Placement                                                           |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| UF/IFAS container example | About 6 in; less than 1 in diameter; two-year wood at the base         | Porous moist medium; at least half buried; base below a node.       |
| Rutgers hardwood approach | About 9 in; pencil to no more than 3/4 in thick; straight woody growth | Base buried, top exposed; well-drained medium or protected nursery. |
| UGA C945 home nursery     | 8–10 in one-year wood; discard soft tips                               | Only upper bud exposed; about 10 in apart in the nursery row.       |

## Do not average protocols

A six-inch container cutting is not “too short” merely because a nursery method uses ten inches. Record which protocol you followed and the actual measurements.

| Measurement check | Worked conversion          |
|-------------------|----------------------------|
| 6 inches          | $6 \times 2.54 = 15.24$ cm |
| 8–10 inches       | 20.32–25.40 cm             |
| 9 inches          | 22.86 cm                   |

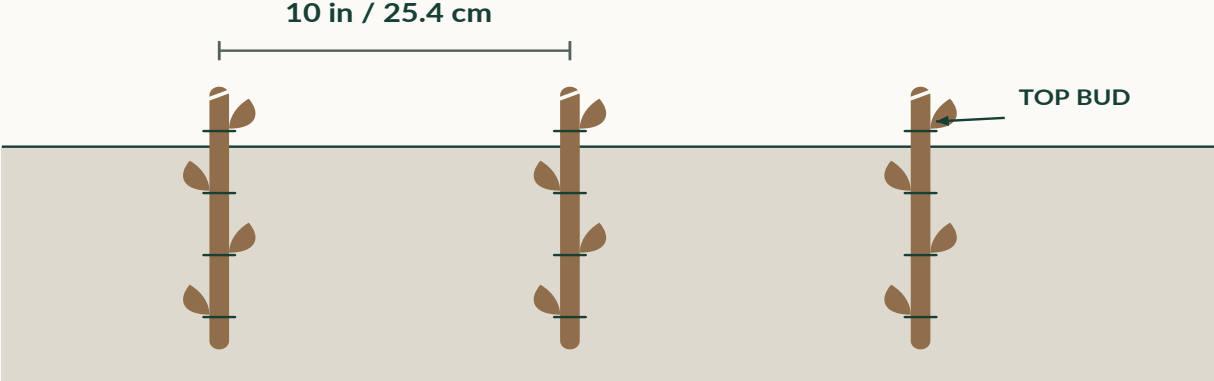
*Choose the route that fits the material and location. The conversions translate units; they do not resolve differences in methods.*

MEASURED ALTERNATIVE

# A nursery row is a propagation bed

OUTDOOR NURSERY ROW — NOT ORCHARD SPACING

10 in / 25.4 cm



UGA C945 home-garden method: 8–10-inch one-year stems, only the top bud exposed. Georgia seasonal guidance is not a national planting date.

| Plan item           | What to record                                                                                             |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Location and timing | UGA specifies late February for its Georgia home-garden method. Use locally suitable conditions elsewhere. |
| Bed identity        | Mark the row so dormant stems are not mistaken for debris.                                                 |
| Maintenance         | Keep the bed appropriately watered and accessible through establishment.                                   |
| Destination         | Rooting-row spacing is not spacing for mature fig trees.                                                   |

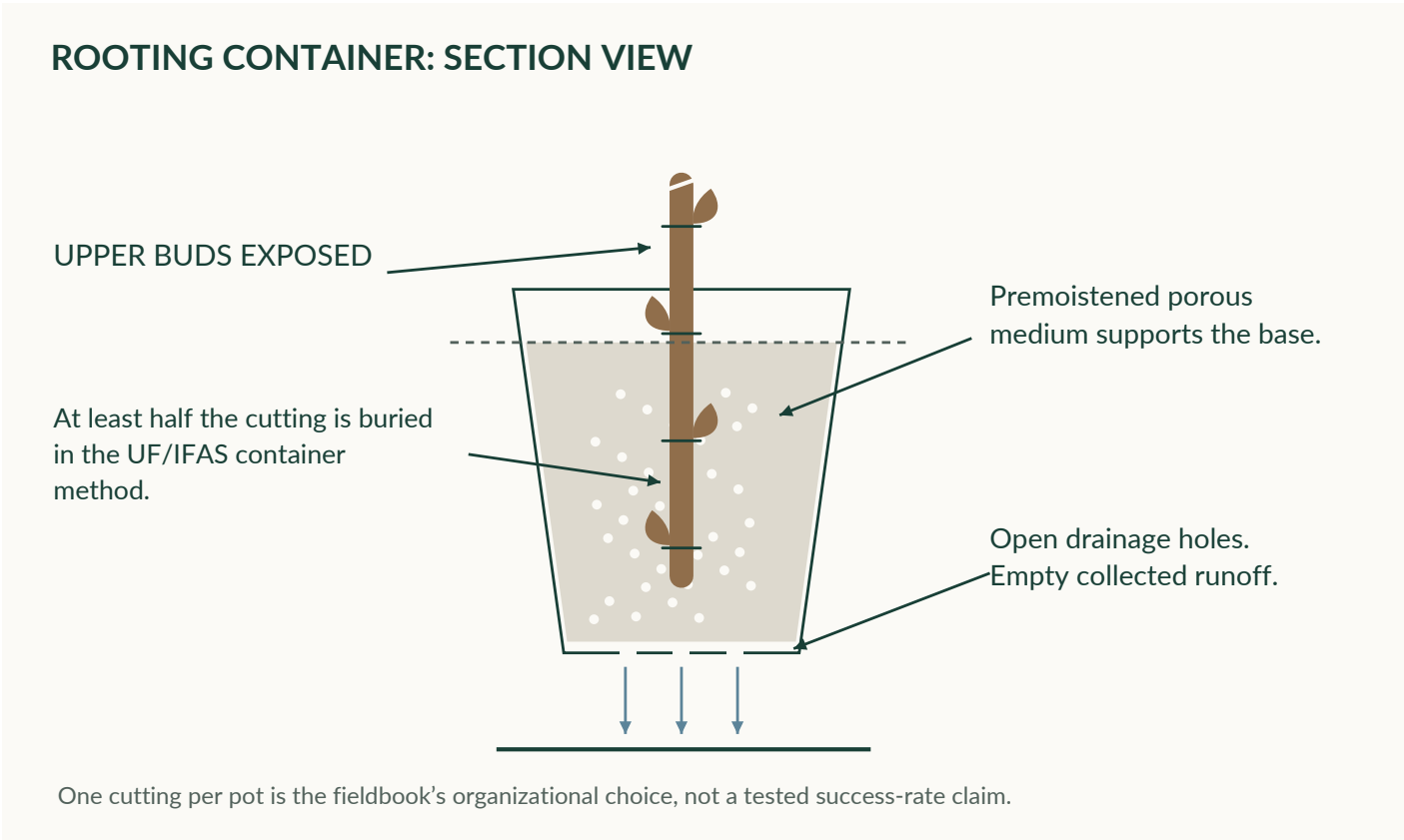
*This page follows C945 specifically. Other propagation publications use different nursery spacing; do not merge their dimensions into this plan.*

Source 8 • UGA C945; Georgia context

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CONTAINER SECTION

# Build the root-zone setup



| Before inserting | Confirm                                                        |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Medium           | Clean porous rooting material, premoistened and drained.       |
| Container        | Open holes, stable base, accessible drainage.                  |
| Cutting          | Correct polarity; intended buried length fits without forcing. |

*The article's main container example follows UF/IFAS. One cutting per pot is used to simplify identity and later handling.*

WORK SURFACE CHECKLIST

# The sticking sequence

| Step        | Physical action                                              | Checkpoint                                 |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| 01 Prepare  | Label pots; moisten and drain medium before cutting.         | The receiving setup is ready.              |
| 02 Identify | Find nodes; mark the basal and upper ends.                   | The correct end is still obvious.          |
| 03 Cut      | Make the selected protocol's cuts with a clean sharp tool.   | No bud is cut through.                     |
| 04 Insert   | Make an opening, insert the base, bring medium into contact. | The stem is supported, not forced.         |
| 05 Drain    | Allow excess water to escape and empty retained runoff.      | No hidden water reservoir.                 |
| 06 Record   | Photograph the label and setup.                              | Date, method and identity are recoverable. |

## Set the batch size before the first cut

Lay out the labels, pots, medium, and aftercare positions first. An extra handful of unlabeled cuttings is not a useful improvement to a traceable small batch.

*Wear gloves when handling fig sap. A rooting product is optional according to the chosen protocol; use its label, not a homemade concentration.*



BENCH PLANNER

# Measure the space you will maintain

A MEASURED BENCH EXAMPLE

40 cm

30 cm

09

10

11

12

05

06

07

08

01

02

03

04

8 × 8 cm pots

10 cm centers

2 cm rim gaps

1 cm edge clearance

12 containers fit geometrically. Re-space as leaves grow; this is not a recommended fig canopy spacing.

| Arithmetic                          | Result                            |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| 4 columns × 3 rows                  | 12 containers                     |
| 10 cm centers – 8 cm pot width      | 2 cm between adjacent rims        |
| $(40 - 3 \times 10 - 8) \div 2$     | 1 cm edge clearance at either end |
| 12 pots × assumed 0.5 L medium each | 6 L medium for this example       |

Replace dimensions and fill volume with measurements of your own pots. Re-space as foliage develops; geometric capacity is not aftercare capacity.

Original geometric example • Not a plant-spacing prescription

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SETUP COMPARISON

# Manage the air and medium separately

## PROTECTED DOES NOT MEAN WATERLOGGED



### BRIGHT, PROTECTED POSITION

Check the real exposure and leave room for new growth. Keep drainage accessible.

### COVER AND WATER ARE DIFFERENT CONTROLS

A cover changes the air around the shoot. It does not turn retained runoff into a suitable rooting medium.

Increase ventilation gradually as the rooted plant adjusts. No universal cover-removal date.

| Observation                         | Next check                                                          |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cover drips; pot remains heavy      | Inspect medium and drainage before watering.                        |
| New leaves reach the cover          | Check clearance and the next ventilation step.                      |
| A direct beam now reaches the setup | Reassess the actual position; do not copy mature-tree sun exposure. |
| Foliage wilts after a change        | Compare exposure with medium condition, not the clock alone.        |

DEVELOPMENT ATLAS

# The three-stage observation plate

THREE OBSERVATIONS, NOT ONE DEADLINE

BUD OPENS



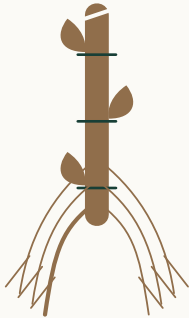
Shoot growth is visible. Root development is still a separate question.

CALLUS



Basal tissue change is not the same as a branching root system.

ROOTS



Record actual roots and later establishment, not only leaf count.

Schematic comparisons. Development rates vary; the drawings do not set a required root count.

| Observation recorded | What it does not establish                   |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Bud opening          | A developed root system.                     |
| Basal callus         | A root count or a ready-to-transplant plant. |
| Roots observed       | Tolerance of every outdoor condition.        |

A rooted plant still has a transition ahead. Do not collapse bud growth, roots, and establishment into one “success” checkbox.

INSPECTION MAP

# Observe roots with minimum disturbance

LOOK WITHOUT REPEATEDLY UPROOTING



**CONTAINER EDGE**  
Record visible roots where the container permits a view.

**DRAINAGE OPENING**  
Look; do not pull roots out through the holes.

Not visible is not the same as absent. Log “not observed without disturbance” instead of inventing a result.

| Entry in the record                  | Meaning                                                      |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| “Roots visible at one opening”       | Root evidence exists at that location.                       |
| “No roots visible on this side”      | That view is negative; the whole root zone is not inspected. |
| “Not inspected to avoid disturbance” | An honest unknown, not a failure.                            |
| “Removed for justified assessment”   | Record the reason and what was actually found.               |

*Repeated tugging changes the setup. Keep the same observational viewpoints where practical.*

MOISTURE LOG

# Measure a change without inventing a dose

| Inspection | Observed evidence                        | Action                                              |
|------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| A          | Medium damp; pot still heavy; tray empty | No water added.                                     |
| B          | Accessible medium drying; pot lighter    | Reassess the whole setup before adding water.       |
| C          | Tray holds runoff after watering         | Remove retained runoff; note the cause.             |
| D          | Medium wet; leaves wilt after moving     | Check exposure and root stage; do not infer thirst. |

## A scale measures mass, not a watering instruction

Fictional observations: the same pot weighs **620 g** after moistening and draining, then **580 g** at a later check.

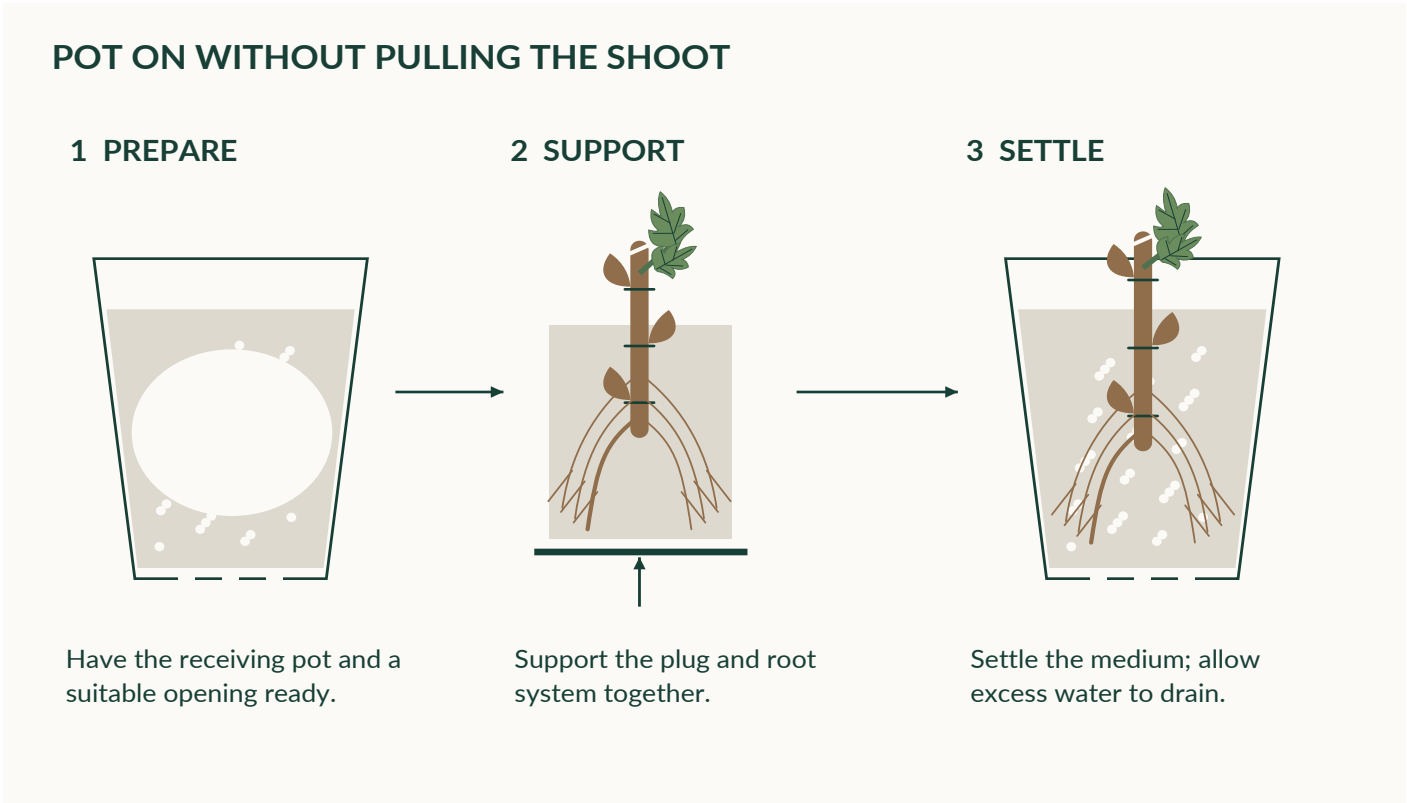
**620 – 580 = 40 g less total mass**

That difference describes this observation. It is not an instruction to pour in 40 mL, proof that roots absorbed 40 mL, or a universal trigger. Repeat measurements only with the same pot, label, cover arrangement, and drainage state.

| Always note            | Useful wording                                   |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| What changed?          | “Cover removed since previous reading.”          |
| What was inaccessible? | “Lower medium not examined without disturbance.” |

HANDLING SEQUENCE

# Prepare the receiving pot first



| Before removal                                  | During handling                                                        | After settling                                            |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Receiving pot and opening ready; label at hand. | Support the root plug and plant together. Do not pull the fresh shoot. | Check drainage and keep exposure suitable for adjustment. |

Container size follows the current root system and method, not the ultimate size of a mature fig tree.

TRANSITION LADDER

# Hardening is a sequence of observations

| Current stage                   | Small next change                              | Observe before advancing                           |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Rooted plant in protected setup | Increase ventilation or reduce cover gradually | Foliage response and actual medium condition.      |
| Tolerating more ventilation     | Move to the prepared, sheltered next position  | Exposure changes, wind, stability and moisture.    |
| Stable in the next position     | Continue gradual adjustment                    | New growth and ability to maintain ordinary care.  |
| Wilt follows a change           | Return to less demanding exposure when needed  | Reassess roots, medium and the size of the change. |

## Separate the variables

Ventilation, light, location, watering, and fertilizer are not one intervention. Write down the specific change before judging its effect.

| Record                   | Your entry |
|--------------------------|------------|
| Plant ID / root evidence | _____      |
| Exposure before → after  | _____      |
| Response / next decision | _____      |

*This ladder intentionally has no universal day count. The decision follows the plant’s response and the conditions available.*

TROUBLESHOOTING ATLAS

# A quiet bud and a soft base are different

DESCRIBE TISSUE BEFORE NAMING A CAUSE

FIRM / QUIET



Review stage and setup. Do not keep cutting it open just because it is quiet.

SHRIVELED



Check actual moisture and recent exposure. Appearance alone is incomplete.

SOFT / DARK



Inspect deterioration and drainage. Separate questionable material for assessment.

These are explanatory signs, not photographs or a pathogen-identification key.

| Bring to a diagnostic review                                                  | Do not claim                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Photo of the whole cutting and pot; dated close-up; moisture/drainage record. | A pathogen identity from color alone.           |
| Sequence of recent changes, including ventilation, light and watering.        | Proof that the last event caused every symptom. |
| Whether nearby cuttings share the pattern.                                    | A universal cultivar failure from one tray.     |



CASE DESK • EVIDENCE

# Case A: leaves arrive before proof of roots

## The observation

CH-04 opens leaves in a protected pot. Its owner plans to transplant it because it looks greener than the other cuttings. No roots have been observed at the available viewing points.

| Claim                                    | Evidence available               | Decision                                      |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| "It has leaves, so it is rooted."        | Only shoot growth is documented. | Not established. Record roots separately.     |
| "No roots at the edge means none exist." | Only one viewpoint was checked.  | Unresolved; do not repeatedly dismantle it.   |
| "It needs fertilizer immediately."       | Root stage remains uncertain.    | Do not replace missing evidence with feeding. |

## The focused route

Keep the setup stable enough to observe. Check medium and drainage, preserve the label, and document root evidence when it becomes visible. Have the receiving pot ready without forcing a transplant today.

| Next observation                    | What changes                                             |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Useful roots and continuing growth  | Assess careful potting and gradual transition.           |
| Softening base or spreading decline | Move to deterioration assessment, not automatic potting. |

CASE DESK • ARITHMETIC

# Case A: score the right milestone

| From a batch of 12           | Count at inspection | Fraction of original batch |
|------------------------------|---------------------|----------------------------|
| Opened buds                  | 9                   | $9 \div 12 = 75\%$         |
| Roots observed               | 6                   | $6 \div 12 = 50\%$         |
| Established after transition | 5                   | $5 \div 12 = 41.7\%$       |

## What these counts actually say

“75% opened buds” is supported by this fictional log. “75% became established plants” is not. Each milestone has its own definition and observation date.

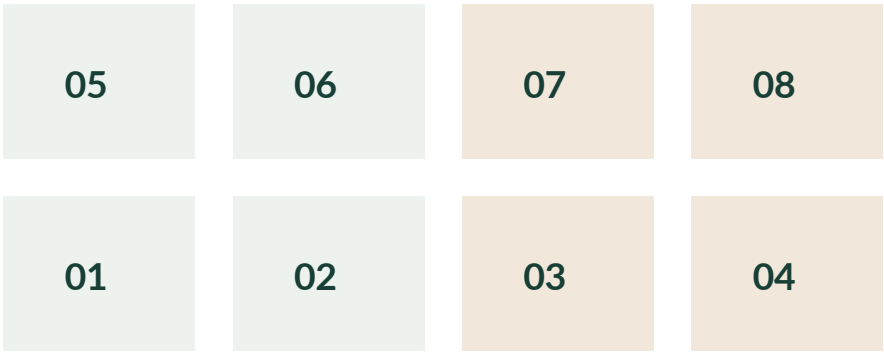
| Milestone definition | Evidence to keep                                        |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Bud opening          | Visible shoot development on a named cutting.           |
| Roots observed       | Root evidence and where it was seen.                    |
| Established          | A stated transition milestone and subsequent condition. |

Keep the original denominator. Removing failed cuttings from the tray does not remove them from the history of the batch.

*Small batches support practical learning. They do not establish a commercial success rate or prove the superiority of a rooting product.*

CASE DESK • POSITION MAP

# Case B: one side of the tray wilts



WINDOW AT RIGHT

Affected: 03, 04, 07, 08

Compare with: 01, 02, 05, 06

In this fictional layout the two right-hand columns share the stronger exposure. Numbering the pots prevents “half the tray” from becoming an ambiguous record.

| Check      | Record                                                    |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Exposure   | Which IDs were reached by direct light or moving air?     |
| Medium     | Was wetness similar in the affected and unaffected pots?  |
| Root stage | Were all cuttings actually at the same stage?             |
| Timing     | Did decline follow a specific move or ventilation change? |

*A spatial pattern identifies a comparison to make. It does not prove the cause on its own.*

CASE DESK • NEXT DECISION

# Case B: one correction, then a comparison

| Finding                                                                  | Focused action                                             | Record next                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Wet medium in both affected and unaffected pots; changed direct exposure | Correct the unsuitable exposure; keep drainage accessible. | Same-angle photos and whether fresh wilt spreads.      |
| Only affected pots retain runoff                                         | Correct that drainage difference.                          | Moisture behavior and condition of the bases.          |
| Affected group has no documented roots                                   | Reassess stage before advancing transition.                | Root evidence without repeated disturbance.            |
| No clear difference found                                                | Keep the unknown explicit; seek closer assessment.         | Whole setup, tissue details and chronological changes. |

## What would change your conclusion?

Write the observation that would cause you to take another route. For example: “If soft basal deterioration appears despite drainage correction, stop treating this as an exposure-only problem.”

*Do not label a pesticide, fertilizer, or hormone as the solution when the organism or deficiency has not been identified.*

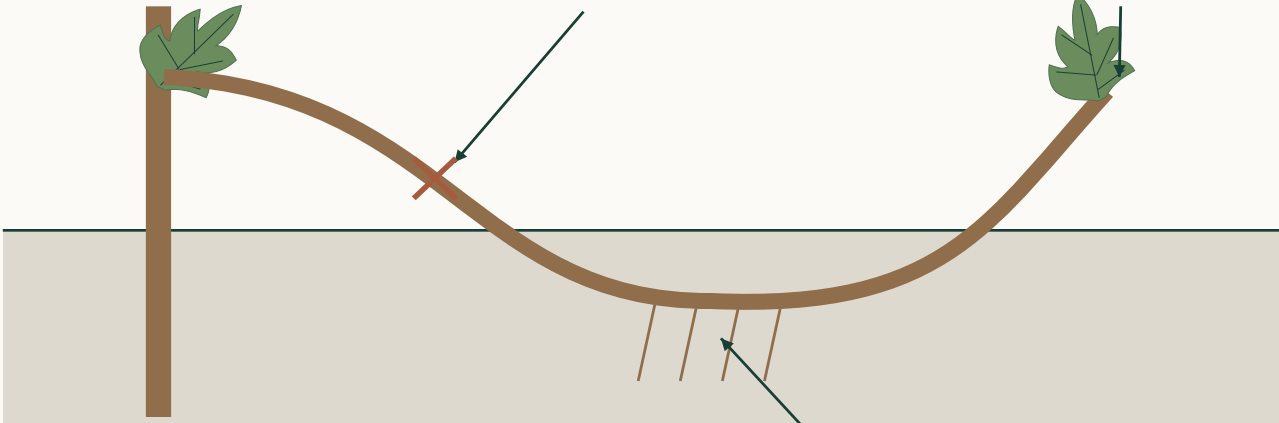
PHYSICAL ALTERNATIVE

# Layer an attached branch instead

ROOT FIRST, SEPARATE LATER

KEEP PARENT ATTACHMENT

TIP ABOVE SOIL



ROOTING ZONE

Separation point shown in rust: cut only after useful roots develop beyond it.

| While attached                                                                                        | Before separation                                                                             |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Secure a suitable flexible branch with its tip above the rooting zone. Maintain appropriate moisture. | Confirm useful roots beyond the intended separation point; prepare aftercare before severing. |

*RHS describes spring or autumn layering for figs. This schematic shows locations, not a required wound depth or a guaranteed rooting interval.*

FIRST-SEASON EXIT PLAN

# Give each new plant a winter destination

| State when cold approaches             | Planning priority                                                   | Do not substitute                                          |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Leafy young fig                        | Suitable light and protection for active growth.                    | Dark dormant storage just because a date arrived.          |
| Naturally leafless, dormant fig        | A locally appropriate protected container plan and moisture checks. | Mature in-ground hardiness claims for a small exposed pot. |
| Freshly rooted late batch              | Aftercare capacity before making more plants.                       | An assumption that all pots fit indoors later.             |
| Unknown decline / unexpected leaf loss | Investigate the context.                                            | Calling every leafless plant dormant.                      |

## Capacity worksheet

Rooting positions: \_\_\_\_  
Receiving-pot positions: \_\_\_\_  
Protected first-winter positions: \_\_\_\_

Use the smallest of these capacities to question the batch size. More cuttings are not automatically more usable plants.

Read the Chicago Hardy fig winter-care guide →

BATCH RECORD

# One compact record that survives potting

| ID    | Stuck            | Roots observed      | Moved / response               |
|-------|------------------|---------------------|--------------------------------|
| CH-01 | Date in notebook | At drainage opening | Ventilated; response recorded. |
| CH-02 | Same batch       | Not observed        | Remain in current stage.       |
| ----  | -----            | -----               | -----                          |
| ----  | -----            | -----               | -----                          |
| ----  | -----            | -----               | -----                          |

## Close the batch with a useful review

| Question                             | Example improvement                               |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Where did identity become uncertain? | Put individual labels in pots before cutting.     |
| Which measurement mattered?          | Note drainage state alongside pot mass.           |
| Which stage was misreported?         | Separate buds, roots and establishment.           |
| What ran out first?                  | Reserve space for receiving pots and winter care. |

Choose one practical improvement for the next batch. Keep the method and observations comparable before judging a new product or technique.

## REFERENCE DESK

# Source key and next resources

1. **Alabama Cooperative Extension** — Fig Production Guide
2. **Rutgers NJAES** — Figs in the Home Garden (FS1198)
3. **UF/IFAS** — The Fig (HS27/MG214)
4. **NC State Extension** — Extension Gardener Handbook: Propagation
5. **Royal Horticultural Society** — Hardwood cuttings
6. **University of Georgia Extension** — Propagating Deciduous Fruit Plants Common to Georgia (B818)
7. **Royal Horticultural Society** — How to grow figs
8. **University of Georgia Extension** — Home Garden Figs (C945)
9. **UF/IFAS** — Plant Propagation Techniques for the Florida Gardener (CIR579/MG108)
10. **N.C. Cooperative Extension, Gates County** — Propagating Figs Through Hardwood Cuttings
11. **Royal Horticultural Society** — Layering

## Continue with the right next task

Chicago Hardy winter care • Container fit and repotting

Chicago Hardy Fig Tree • Fruit-tree collection

*Cultivation claims are attributed by source number. Diagrams, bench layouts, example measurements, cases and records are original instructional tools. They are not observed trial results or guaranteed rooting performance.*